



The Foundation School

Presents

Junior Model United Nations



THE Continuous Crisis Committee



Agenda: South China Sea Escalation

Freeze Date: 15 June 2024

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LETTER FROM EXECUTIVE BOARD

Dear Delegates,

It is our privilege to welcome you to the Continuous Crisis Committee on the South China Sea Escalation. The South China Sea has become one of the world's most contested strategic theatres, where questions of sovereignty, international law, economic security, and military deterrence intersect. A single miscalculation has the potential to reshape regional stability and redefine the balance of power across the Indo-Pacific. As members of this Continuous Crisis Committee, your decisions will influence events that may determine whether diplomacy prevails or conflict becomes inevitable.

Few flashpoints in contemporary geopolitics carry the same combination of legal complexity, historical grievance, and raw military risk as the South China Sea. Nearly a third of global maritime trade, hundreds of billions of dollars in undersea energy reserves, and the credibility of decades-old alliance systems all converge in a body of water that six governments claim, in whole or in part, as their own.

This committee rewards authenticity, strategic thinking, and crisis responsiveness. Research your portfolio's real-world statements, constraints, and red lines. Coordinate—but also anticipate betrayal.

Most importantly, remember, that in crisis, inaction is also a decision.

The world is watching.

Good Luck.

-Executive Board

RULES OF PROCEDURE

TYPES OF REPRESENTATION:

In a Continuous Crisis Committee, the delegates are either given a Portfolio Representation or a Country Representation. Based on what/ whom they represent, the following is implied:

- **Portfolio Representation:** The delegates are given a specific person with relevance to the agenda, and he/she has to abide by that portfolio. The committee at hand will be a Portfolio committee, where delegates will be given roles of people. It must be kept in mind that the key is authenticity, and the more evidence gathered and showcased from press statements, biographies, personal writings, or other viable sources would enhance the delegate's stance.
- **Country Representation:** The delegate will be given the role of a country in relevance to the specified agenda. When representing their country, the delegates must keep in mind the country's foreign policy, internal policy, external affairs, official statements, documents and more in regard to their country.

NOTE: This committee will be a "Portfolio Committee."

ROLL CALL:

At the beginning of each day of the committee, a roll call will be conducted to ensure all portfolios are accounted for. The members of the Executive Board will call out the portfolios, and the portfolios will answer as follows:

- Present and Voting: The delegate is present in the committee, and loses his/her right to abstain during voting, i.e., he/she must either vote 'For' or 'Against' when the Final documentation is at hand.
- Present: The delegate is present in committee, but retains his/her right to abstain from voting, i.e., he/she is not required to necessarily vote in the Final Documentation.
- Absent: The portfolio is simply absent.

NOTE: In a Crisis Committee, once said to be 'Present and Voting' cannot change his/her decision from the other day. However, he/she who had said 'Present' on day one may change it or remain as 'Present'.

NOTE: In a Crisis Committee, a simple majority, i.e., more than 50 % votes, will result in the motion passing.

POINTS:

Points are rights that the delegates enjoy during a committee session. They need to be addressed to the Executive Board for approval, then after which they can proceed with their point.

FORMAT: "I, the delegate of XXXX, would like to raise a point of XXXX."

Points are noted as follows-

- Point Of Personal Privilege [POPP]: Ensures the personal comforts of the delegate are tended to, such as usage of the washroom, asking a delegate to reiterate a part of his/her speech, using the infirmary, taking a delegate outside to talk, etc.
- Point Of Parliamentary Inquiry [POPI]: If a delegate is unaware of committee proceedings, then he/she may raise this point to clarify the rules of procedure or to know the status of the committee at that standpoint.
- Point Of Order [POO]: It is of two types-
 - Point Of Factual Inaccuracy [POFI]: When in a speech, the delegate puts out incorrect information, this point can be raised and corrected.
 - Point Of Logical Fallacy [POLF]: When in a speech, the delegate makes a logically flawed statement, i.e., it makes no absolute sense and is technically not possible, then this point can be raised and pointed out.

- Point Of Information [POI]: After a delegate completes his/her speech, this point can be raised to ask pertinent questions relevant to the agenda of the speech.
- Point Of Comment [POC]: This point can be raised by the EB or any delegates after his/her speech is completed. This must be done under procedure and guidelines, and replaces POI's.

FORMS OF DEBATE

The delegates can engage in the following forms of debate:

- **General Speaker's List:** These are generally ongoing debates that are non-exhaustive and are generalized to discuss the agenda and the portfolio's stance as a whole. The time may be specified between 60 to 90 seconds once a motion is raised and passed by the EB, and it continues throughout the next two days.
- **Moderated Caucus:** These are localized debates on a specific sub-topic on the agenda, with a TOTAL time limit for the entire caucus and a time limit for each speaker. It is up to the EB's discretion to select the delegates who get to speak in the caucus, keeping in mind the delegate who raised the motion {*the delegate who raised the motion gets a reservation to speak on that topic}
- **Unmoderated Caucus:** These are informal discussions where the delegates specify a particular time period. They may freely move around and talk or lobby with fellow delegates without any EB interventions.
- **Right to Reply [RTR]:** When a delegate feels as if the speaker has said something against their country/portfolio or hurt them, then they may raise a RTR. An RTR consists of both speakers giving their speeches and stances.

- Provisional Speakers List: based on all the front room speeches and debates heard until then, the PSL will consist of the best of the best speakers, who will be selected by the EB's discretion and past performances.
- Round Robin: These are quick and formal, rapid-fire sessions where the list of solutions that a delegate believes may be stated down by him/her in a span of 45 seconds or less. This is only invoked to ensure every person gets the privilege of representation.

YIELDS:

When a delegate finishes their speech before the allotted timeframe has passed, they may yield the remaining time of their speech in the following manner:

- Yield to POIs: They utilize the rest of their time entertaining POIs from the rest of the delegates.
- Yield for comments: They utilize the rest of their time entertaining comments from the rest of the delegates.
- Yield to the EB: The EB decides what to do with the Time.
- Yield to another delegate: The time is given to another delegate.

DOCUMENTATION IN CRISIS COMMITTEE-

CRISIS TOOLS:

The heart and soul of the Crisis committee not only lies in the front room of a delegate, but also in the backroom where the crises unfold. This is implemented in the form of crisis documentation, which can only be sent in discrete time periods, called “Crisis Windows,” that are opened and closed by the members of the EB.

The Crisis Tools are in the manner of-

1. Directives:

Directives are a form of documentation where the delegate can write what they want to bring out in committee. E.g.- I want to provide Venezuela with economic support, I may write a directive.

Directives are a form of crisis tools where the delegate may exercise certain powers that they have, in accordance with their portfolio. A directive must be plausible and realistic and, thus, make sense to be achieved.

The delegate must be really careful while writing their directive. It must be noted that the EB will not always understand the directive in the way the delegate meant for it to be, hence, backfiring.

E.g.: A delegate planning on a missile strike to another country (only to harm that country) may cause an all-out nuclear war, hence wiping out over 80% of their population, significantly depleting their national resources and destroying any hope of recovery.

Therefore, the directives must be well-thought-out and written in such a manner by the delegate to prevent any loopholes or flaws. The directive flow of a delegate must contain the following:

- Quality: The details, content, reason behind it, thoughts, legalities, etc.
- Quantity: The number of pages a directive is, and the number of directives a delegate sends out.
- Accuracy: This refers to the factual accuracy (factual correctness) of the directive and the ability of the delegate to send it in accordance to their portfolio.

CHITS:

SUBSTANTIVE

From: the delegate of [delegation]

Via Eb

(content)

POINT OF ____

From: the delegate of [delegation]

To: the delegate of [delegation]

Via / Not via EB

(content)

Types of Directives

- Overt Directive: These directives are open. they will be informed of the entire committee at hand, regardless of the outcome. Hence, this is said to be like a public statement. E.g.- A declaration of war, a public action, an announcement about a course of action, etc.
- Covert Directive: These directives are kept confidential, and only mentioned in the 'Crisis Window' if the directive, successful or backfired, has a huge impact on the committee. E.g.- Assassination directive, intelligentsia spying, a surprise missile launch, etc.
- NOTE: When a delegate does not mention the type of directive, it is taken to be an 'Overt' one.

Format of the Directive:

COVERT/ OVERT DIRECTIVE

To: The Executive Board.

From: XXXX. (Portfolio writing the directive)

Type: Individual/Joint

Signatories: XXXX. (Members who agree to read and are a part of it)

Date: DD/MM/YYYY

Primary objective: XXXX.

Secondary objective: XXXX.

Plan of Action: (What you are doing.)

Requirements/Resources:

Body: (Divide it into paragraphs- how you are doing it.)

Expected Outcome: (What is the likely effect of this directive.)

COMMUNIQUE

Communiques are used by delegates in order to request an external portfolio that is not seen as present or represented in the committee. This is required as sometimes there may not be a portfolio present or represented by a delegate in the committee. At this time, when a delegate needs assistance from such a portfolio, they may write a communique to fulfil their requirements.

NOTE: A communique is more formal than a directive and will be accepted at the discretion of the EB. It depends on the portfolio that has been requested and the crisis.

Format of the Communique:

Communique

To: XXXX (The External Entity)

via the Executive Board.

From: XXXX. (The delegate's portfolio)

Dear XXXX, (External Entity)

BODY. (Must be pleading/requesting in tone for better reading)

Preferred outcome: XXXX.

PRESS RELEASES

These are statements made by the delegate in the form of a press statement to the general public in the world that the agenda is set in. The press release is generally read out to the committee if passed; however, it is meant for the public. It may be in the order specified by the delegate or anonymous, to maintain suspense.

Format of a Press Release:

PRESS RELEASE

From: (The delegate who wrote it- Can specify if they want it anonymous.)

TITLE OF PRESS RELEASE

BODY

INTRODUCTION TO THE TOPIC

When the South China Sea sneezes, the world economy catches a cold.

The South China Sea is a 3.5-million-square-kilometer semi-enclosed sea bounded by China and Taiwan to the north, Vietnam to the west, the Philippines to the east, and Malaysia, Brunei, and Indonesia to the south.

Six governments — China, Taiwan, Vietnam, the Philippines, Malaysia, and Brunei — assert overlapping claims over some combination of the Paracel Islands, the Spratly Islands, Scarborough Shoal, and the surrounding waters. China's claim is the most expansive: it is built around the "nine-dash line," a boundary first depicted on Chinese maps in 1947 that encloses roughly 80–90% of the sea, including areas hundreds of kilometers from the Chinese mainland and well within the internationally recognized Exclusive Economic Zones (EEZs) of its neighbors.

Every year nearly **one-third** of global maritime trade (\$3.37 trillion in global ship-borne trade annually) passes through the South China Sea. Beneath its waters lie **significant fisheries** and **hydrocarbon reserves**, while its islands and reefs have become focal points of competing sovereignty claims. Overlapping territorial assertions, expanding military presence, and strategic rivalry among regional and extra-regional powers have transformed the region into one of the world's most volatile flashpoints.

Overlapping sovereignty and maritime claims by China, Taiwan, the Philippines, Vietnam, Malaysia, Brunei, and Indonesia have created a persistent risk of confrontation. The dispute is further complicated by the involvement of external powers—especially the United States, Japan, Australia, and India—who conduct freedom of navigation operations (FONOPs) and security partnerships to counter perceived Chinese expansion

The Road to the Brink

This war did not begin with the firing of missiles or the declaration of hostilities. Instead, it began with a fishing boat.

Chapter 1: A Sea Worth Fighting for

Stretching across approximately 3.5 million square kilometres, the South China Sea connects the Pacific and Indian Oceans through vital maritime corridors such as the Strait of Malacca, the Taiwan Strait, and the Luzon Strait. It contains more than 250 islands, reefs, shoals, and atolls, most of them tiny, uninhabited, and incapable of supporting permanent populations. Yet these seemingly insignificant features have become the centre of one of the most dangerous geopolitical disputes of the twenty-first century.

Nearly one-third of global maritime trade, valued at over \$3 trillion annually, passes through these waters. The sea supports an estimated 10–12% of the world's fisheries, sustaining millions of livelihoods across Southeast Asia. Beneath its seabed are significant reserves of oil and natural gas, while its location makes it indispensable to military logistics, energy security, and international commerce. Control of the South China Sea therefore represents far more than territorial prestige—it is synonymous with economic influence, strategic depth, and regional power projection.

Chapter 2: Ancient Water and Ancient Claims

Yet long before warships and coast guards patrolled these waters, the South China Sea was a highway of commerce. Chinese, Malay, Cham, Arab, Indian, and later European traders navigated its routes for centuries. Fishermen from present-day China, Vietnam, the Philippines, Malaysia, and Indonesia seasonally visited many of the reefs and islands, often leaving little permanent evidence of occupation. These early voyages would later become the foundation for competing historical narratives, with multiple governments citing records of navigation, fishing, taxation, and imperial administration as evidence of sovereignty.

Chapter 3: Empires and the Colonial Legacy

The arrival of European colonial powers fundamentally transformed the nature of territorial claims. During the nineteenth century, France expanded its control over French Indochina, administering present-day Vietnam, Laos, and Cambodia. French authorities gradually asserted administrative control over several features in the Paracel and Spratly Islands, establishing weather stations, conducting surveys, and incorporating certain islands into colonial governance.

Meanwhile, Britain consolidated its influence over Malaya and Singapore, while Spain—and later the United States following the Spanish-American War—administered the Philippine archipelago. Although these colonial powers rarely viewed the scattered reefs as strategically significant, their administrative decisions would later become central to the sovereignty claims of the independent states that succeeded them.

The Second World War transformed the South China Sea from a commercial crossroads into a military theatre. Imperial Japan occupied much of the region, including the Paracel and Spratly Islands, using them to support its broader campaign across the Pacific. For the first time, the strategic military value of these remote maritime features became unmistakably clear.

Following Japan's surrender in 1945, the Treaty of San Francisco required Japan to renounce its claims over many occupied territories but deliberately refrained from specifying a successor state for the disputed islands. Rather than resolving sovereignty, the post-war settlement created a legal vacuum that persists to this day.

Chapter 4: The Cold War, Lines drawn across the Sea

The years following the Second World War witnessed the birth of the maps that continue to shape contemporary disputes.

In 1947, the Republic of China (ROC) published the Eleven-Dash Line, enclosing much of the South China Sea based on historical claims. Following the establishment of the People's Republic of China (PRC) in 1949, Beijing inherited this map and later modified it into the Nine-Dash Line, eventually adding a tenth dash east of Taiwan in 2023. Unlike modern maritime boundaries, these lines did not clearly define whether China claimed the waters themselves, the islands, or broader historic rights—an ambiguity that has become one of the central legal controversies in the dispute.

As decolonization swept across Southeast Asia, newly independent states inherited colonial-era administrative boundaries and asserted sovereignty over nearby maritime features. Vietnam, reunified under communist rule in 1975, inherited the claims previously advanced by both North and South Vietnam, while the Philippines, Malaysia, and Brunei increasingly based their claims on geographic proximity and continental shelf principles.

The Cold War also witnessed the first major armed confrontations. In 1974, Chinese and South Vietnamese forces clashed over the Paracel Islands, resulting in China's effective control of the archipelago. Fourteen years later, in 1988, Chinese and Vietnamese naval forces fought at Johnson South Reef in the Spratly Islands, leaving dozens of Vietnamese sailors dead and further militarizing the dispute.

What had once been competing historical narratives had now become armed territorial conflicts.

Chapter 5: Law and Order

The adoption of the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS) in 1982 fundamentally reshaped maritime governance. Often described as the "constitution of the oceans," UNCLOS introduced standardized maritime zones, including a 12-nautical-mile territorial sea and a 200-nautical-mile Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ), granting coastal states sovereign rights over marine resources within those areas.

For Southeast Asian claimant states, UNCLOS offered an objective legal framework grounded in geography. For China, however, historical rights represented by the Nine-Dash Line remained central to its position. This divergence created an enduring legal and diplomatic impasse: while several claimant states relied primarily on UNCLOS, China argued that its historical rights predated the Convention and therefore retained legal significance.

The disagreement culminated in 2013, when the Philippines initiated arbitration proceedings under UNCLOS. Three years later, the Permanent Court of Arbitration (PCA) in The Hague ruled overwhelmingly in Manila's favour, concluding that China's expansive historical claims within the Nine-Dash Line had no legal basis under UNCLOS. Beijing rejected the ruling, declaring it "null and void," while continuing to strengthen its presence throughout the region.

Rather than settling the dispute, the judgment deepened the divide between legal legitimacy and geopolitical reality.

Chapter 6: Claims on the Sea

Beginning around 2013, the South China Sea entered a new phase. Rather than relying solely on legal arguments or historical narratives, claimant states—most notably China—began physically transforming the maritime landscape.

Through extensive land reclamation, submerged reefs were converted into artificial islands equipped with airstrips, deep-water harbours, radar installations, missile shelters, and military garrisons. Between 2013 and 2017, China reclaimed more than 3,200 acres (approximately 13 square kilometres) of land, constructing military-grade infrastructure across several disputed features in the Spratly Islands.

Although UNCLOS distinguishes artificial islands from naturally formed islands and does not grant them expanded maritime entitlements, these installations dramatically enhanced China's ability to sustain continuous military and coast guard operations far from its mainland.

The South China Sea was no longer merely disputed—it was increasingly fortified.

Chapter 7: The Grand Finale

Traditional warfare begins with declarations, mobilization orders, and unmistakable acts of aggression. Grey-zone competition does the opposite. It seeks to alter the status quo through persistent actions that are individually too limited to justify a conventional military response but collectively capable of reshaping strategic realities.

China has become the most prominent practitioner of grey-zone tactics in the South China Sea, although other states have also adopted elements of this approach. Instead of leading with destroyers or aircraft carriers, Beijing frequently employs its China Coast Guard and a vast maritime militia—civilian fishing vessels

operating with varying degrees of state support—to assert jurisdiction over contested waters.

Imagine a routine resupply mission heading toward Second Thomas Shoal. The Philippine vessel is not intercepted by warships. Instead, dozens of fishing boats suddenly converge around the reef. Soon afterwards, large white-hulled coast guard ships appear, blocking the vessel's path. Water cannons are fired. High-powered lasers are reportedly directed toward bridge crews. Dangerous manoeuvres force the smaller vessel off course. Cameras record every second. Social media erupts. Governments exchange diplomatic protests.

No missiles have been launched. No state has formally declared war. Yet strategic control over the area has subtly shifted.

This is the defining characteristic of grey-zone competition: every action remains carefully calibrated to remain below the threshold that would trigger a conventional military response or mutual defence obligations. Coast guards replace navies. Fishing fleets become instruments of statecraft. Legal narratives accompany maritime manoeuvres. Cyber operations, GPS interference, economic pressure, and information campaigns reinforce activities at sea.

Each individual incident appears manageable. Together, they gradually normalize a new strategic reality.

KEY TERMS

Legal

- UNCLOS
- EEZ
- Continental Shelf
- Territorial Sea
- Innocent Passage
- Permanent Court of Arbitration (PCA) Ruling, 2016

Military

- FONOP
- Rules of Engagement
- Maritime Domain Awareness
- Code of Conduct

Strategic

- Grey-Zone Warfare
- Salami Slicing
- Maritime Militia
- Strategic Ambiguity
- Deterrence

IMPORTANT EVENTS

1939–1945 – Japanese Occupation of the South China Sea

1945 – End of World War II

1947 – Publication of the Eleven-Dash Line

1974 – Battle of the Paracel Islands

1975 – Reunification of Vietnam

1982 – Adoption of UNCLOS

2002 – Declaration on the Conduct of Parties (DOC)

2013–2017 – Artificial Island Construction

2016 – Permanent Court of Arbitration Award

2021 – China Coast Guard Law

2022 – Marcos Jr.'s Strategic Pivot

2023 – Escalation of Grey-Zone Tactics

2024 – Rising Maritime Confrontation

15 June 2024 – Committee Freeze Date

MAPS

1.



QARMA

NOTE:

-In the Continuous Crisis Committee, we 'do not' have a 'Resolution,' but instead, we have a 'Working Sheet.'

-The Working Sheet is simply a resolution, but a liberal(lenient) form of it.

-The Working Sheet is a resolution, but with fewer formatting codes, which helps the delegates note down more resolutions.

NOTE: *During committee sessions and in the BG Guide, when we refer to the documentation form of resolution, it means a "Working Sheet."*

QARMA stands for 'Questions A Resolution Must Answer'. We will thoroughly discuss the resolution throughout the committee, especially during the last committee session. The questions a resolution must answer are:

1. What immediate measures should the international community adopt to contain escalating tensions in the South China Sea, and what long-term diplomatic, legal, and security framework can ensure sustainable peace, stability, and freedom of navigation in the region?
2. What role, if any, should external powers—including the United States, Japan, Australia, and other extra-regional stakeholders—play in

safeguarding regional security without transforming the South China Sea into a theatre of great-power rivalry?

3. How can the international community establish a sustainable, rules-based governance framework that ensures the peaceful, equitable, and environmentally responsible utilization of the South China Sea's natural resources, while preventing future conflicts and upholding international law?

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THANK YOU

